

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up

The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with imagination and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only kind new ideas to try.*

Before you begin

It is festival day in the Lantern Village. All morning the market has been getting ready, with stalls of paper fans, baskets of fruit, and rows of glowing lanterns. But oh dear. Pon the Tanuki was so excited that he bounced and rolled right through the market, and he knocked every stall over by mistake. Now the fans, the fruit, and the lanterns are all in one big jumble, and Pon feels terrible.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper calls you to her. "You two have heads full of ideas and kind hearts," she says. "Will you help Pon set the market right before the festival opens?"

She gives you three gifts: a ball of red thread, a little bell, and a sweet rice cake. Then she smiles. "Up here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Imagination, of Courage, or of Kindness?*

Stop 1 The Jumbled Stalls

You hurry to the market and find Pon the Tanuki sitting in the middle of the mess. His ears droop. His nose wobbles. "I have spoiled everything," he sniffs. "I only wanted to help."

He is too upset to tidy up. He needs a kind word first.

★ *What could you do to help Pon feel better? You could sit beside him. You could tell him it was an accident. You could say that everyone can fix a muddle together. What do you try?*

When you are kind to Pon, he wipes his nose and gives a little smile. "You are good friends," he says. "Let us tidy up together." And he jumps up, ready to help.

Stop 2 The Great Sort

Now you look at the jumble. Fans, fruit, and lanterns are all mixed up in one big heap. Everything must go back to the right stall before the festival opens.

The fans belong on the fan stall. The fruit belongs in the fruit baskets. The lanterns belong on the lantern posts. You will need to sort them, and count them, and match them up.

★ *How will you sort it all out? Could you make a pile for each kind of thing? Could you count the lanterns onto the posts? Could you match the fruit by its colour? What is your plan?*

When you sort and count it all back into place, the market begins to look right again. Pon claps his paws. "What a good idea!" he says.

Stop 3 The Last Lantern

The market is nearly perfect. But one lantern is still missing: the big red festival lantern that hangs over the very middle of the market. Without it, the festival cannot begin.

Then Kon the Fox trots out of the bamboo. "I saw something round and red roll under the plum tree by the bridge," he says with a wink. "Follow my clue."



Where could the last lantern be? Could you follow Kon's clue to the plum tree? Could you ask Pon to help you look? What do you do?

You follow the clue and there it is, the big red lantern, safe under the plum tree. You carry it back and hang it high. "I found the spot it rolled to," says Pon proudly. "I helped after all." And he stands a little taller.

The Festival Opens

The market is set right at last. Every fan is fanned out, every basket of fruit is neat, and every lantern glows warm in its place, with the big red one shining in the middle.

Pon the Tanuki is forgiven, and best of all, he is proud. The drum begins to beat, the people come laughing into the square, and the festival opens at last.

High above, Amaterasu the Sun-Kami looks down and smiles. You did it together. You were brave, you were kind, and most of all, you were full of ideas. Well done, heroes of the Lantern Village.

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the whole game works. This page holds only what is special about this story. This is a gentle, warm tale with no villain at all: the only trouble is a happy muddle, and imagination and kindness set it right every time. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Lantern Village market.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the red thread, a small bell or jingly thing for the little bell, and any small treat or token for the rice cake. Anything can be anything.
- A handful of buttons, coins, or bricks in two or three colours makes the sorting in Stop 2 lovely and hands-on. It is not needed, but it helps.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The Twist of Fate

Once at each place the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Kon the Fox trots by and gives you one free hint.
2	You gather your calm again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts through, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Guardian Lion-Dogs nod kindly from the gate. All is well.
5	A lucky cherry petal floats down: keep one roll to use again later.
6	The soft ring of a temple bell, and for a moment everyone feels calm.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all. The trouble is only a friendly muddle made by Pon the Tanuki, who feels dreadful about it and most needs a kind word. The story is won by calming and reassuring Pon, by patiently sorting and counting the market back into place, and by helping Pon end the day proud rather than ashamed. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward kindness and imagination over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Jumbled Stalls (Easy)

The challenge. Pon the Tanuki sits in the middle of the toppled market, too upset and flustered to help. He has knocked everything over by accident and feels he has spoiled the festival. Before any tidying can begin, the players must calm and reassure him.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Kindness and Observation. The players notice that Pon is not naughty, only sad, and offer comfort: sitting beside him, telling him it was an accident, reminding him that everyone topples things sometimes, or promising that the muddle is smaller when friends fix it together. Sharing the rice cake works beautifully too. Any genuine kindness lifts his ears and gets him on his feet.

Fallback. If the children are unsure what to say, have Pon sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Do you think I am a bad tanuki?" A single warm "no" melts the worry at once. A friendly pat or a shared rice cake also does the trick, and Pon springs up, ready to help.

Make it simpler. For a very little one, just ask them to give Pon a big gentle hug and say "it's all right," and his ears perk straight up.

Stop 2: The Great Sort (Normal)

The challenge. Fans, fruit, and lanterns lie jumbled in one big heap. The players must sort, count, and match everything back to the right stall before the festival opens.

Intended solution. This is a Maths, Logic, and Observation moment. The thoughtful move is to sort by kind first, then count and match. A worked example to guide them: make three piles, one for fans, one for fruit, one for lanterns. Fan out the fans on the fan stall. Sort the fruit by colour, the red plums into the red basket and the golden persimmons into the gold basket. Then count the lanterns onto the posts, the same number on each, say three posts with four lanterns each, twelve lanterns in all. Counting aloud together is the heart of this stop. Use buttons or bricks in colours if you have them, so small hands can sort for real.

Fallback. If the counting wobbles, do one pile together out loud and let them copy the pattern for the rest, or let Pon "remember" where one kind of thing goes. Spending an energy star to take a calm breath and start the pile again always works. Getting the market tidy with help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a very little one, hand them just the red things and ask them to pop them all in one basket, and that one tidy pile is a win.

Stop 3: The Last Lantern (Normal)

The challenge. The market is nearly perfect, but the big red festival lantern that hangs over the centre is still missing, and the festival cannot begin without it. The players must follow a clue to find it, and help Pon feel proud rather than ashamed.

Intended solution. This is an Imagination and Kindness moment. **Kon the Fox** offers the clue: something round and red rolled away, down the lane, under the old plum tree by the bridge. The thoughtful players follow the clue and think where a runaway lantern likes to hide, and there it is, safe under the tree. Just as important, they let Pon join the search and be the one to spot the branch it caught on, so the day ends with Pon proud of helping rather than sorry for the muddle.

Fallback. If the clue is too tricky, have Kon make it plainer ("look low, near water, where the plums grow"), or let Pon catch a glimpse of red himself. However the lantern is found, make sure Pon gets the credit for the finding, so he ends the story standing tall.

Make it simpler. For a very little one, hide a red toy or ball nearby and let them toddle over and find it, then cheer that they saved the festival.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, and there never was a foe. When the last lantern is hung, the whole market glows, Pon the Tanuki is forgiven and proud, the drum beats and the festival opens, and **Amaterasu the Sun-Kami** smiles down from the warm sky. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

Content licence: CC BY-SA 4.0 (<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>)

Version 6.2, updated 2026-06-06, en-GB



Scan for the latest version

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.